

Are You the GOAT?

Design Brainstorm Doc — spin-built players, random team drops, simulated seasons

v0.1 · July 2026 · Working design doc, not final spec

Core Loop

- Name your player — one text input before any spins, ties you to the build and feeds the recap headline
- Spin Height, then Body Frame — sets the physical identity before anything else
- Spin the 5 skill wheels (Shooting, Finishing, Playmaking, Defense, Rebounding) against a 100-pt Budget Cap, with 3 total rerolls to use across the whole build
- Choose a Position last — fit your build or gamble on a positional anomaly
- Spin the team wheel — your built player randomly lands on one of 30 rosters
- Simulate the season — wins, playoffs, awards, career totals
- Get the Verdict — tier ladder placement (Draft Bust up to GOAT), percentile rank, recap headline
- Play again — chase a new personal best

The 7 Attribute Wheels

Five core skill wheels plus two physical wheels. Each skill wheel pulls from a curated pool of ~10–12 real players (any era) who each carry a 0–99 rating for that specific category only — so a player can show up on multiple wheels with different values (e.g. LeBron might be 78 on the Shooting wheel but 96 on the Playmaking wheel).

Height and Body Frame spin **first**, before any skill wheel — that sets your player's physical identity up front, so every skill spin after it lands with more context (watching to see if a 7'4" frame gets matched with elite Finishing, or cursed with a 61 Shooting rating).

Spin order	Wheel	What it measures	Example pool (any-era)
1	Height	Listed height, mapped to a rating	5'9" (Boykins) up to 7'4" (Wembanyama)
2	Body Frame	Build archetype: Slight / Athletic / Bulky / Powerful	Curry (Slight) to prime Shaq (Powerful)
3	Shooting	Volume + efficiency from deep/mid	Curry, Ray Allen, Klay, Durant, Ant
4	Finishing	Rim pressure, contact finishing, footwork	Shaq, Giannis, Kareem, Zion, Embiid
5	Playmaking	Vision, assists, ball control	Magic, Jokic, Stockton, Nash, Trae
6	Defense	Perimeter + interior defense, IQ	Mobley, Gobert, Kawhi, Bill Russell
7	Rebounding	Box-outs, positioning, effort	Rodman, Sabonis, Wilt, Barkley
8	Position	Chosen last, not spun — see Positional Bias	PG / SG / SF / PF / C

Height & Frame as modifiers, not raw stats

Instead of just being flavor, Height and Frame push and pull the other 5 stats. This is the mechanic Hoopgoat doesn't have, and it's what makes extreme builds (like a 7'4" playmaker) feel meaningfully different from a balanced build, in both directions.

Trait	Rating conversion	Boosts	Penalizes
Height	5'9" = 30 (linear scale between)	Rebounding, Defense	Playmaking, Shooting (if 90+)
Frame	Slight = 30, Athletic = 60, Bulky = 80, Powerful = 99	Finishing, Rebounding, Defense	Playmaking, Shooting (if 90+)

Modifier formula (applied per affected stat, after the base wheel spin result):

```
StatFinal = StatBase + ((HeightRating - 70) × 0.15) + ((FrameRating - 70) × 0.15)
clamp(StatFinal, 25, 99)
```

70 is the "neutral" baseline (roughly 6'6", Athletic build), so anything taller/bulkier than that nudges Reb/Def/Finishing up and Shooting/Playmaking down, and vice versa for smaller/lighter builds.

Budget Cap: 100 Points

The piece Hoopgoat gets right that pure random spinning doesn't: you can't just stack elite result after elite result. Every skill wheel result costs budget, and once you're out, you're out — so the wheel stays exciting (you don't pick your outcome) while the cap still forces real tradeoffs.

```
WheelCost = round(Rating × 0.15)
e.g. a 99-rated legend costs 15 · a 60-rated role player costs 9
```

- Applies to the 5 skill wheels only (Shooting, Finishing, Playmaking, Defense, Rebounding) — Height and Frame are free since they're spun first to set identity, not "drafted"
- Maxing all 5 skill wheels (15 × 5 = 75) still leaves room, so the real tension comes from bad luck on early spins eating into what you can afford later
- **3 total rerolls per build**, free of budget cost — use them wherever you want across the 5 skill wheels (all 3 on one wheel if you're chasing a specific legend, or spread across several). Once they're spent, every spin after that is locked in.
- If remaining budget can't afford anything in a wheel's normal pool, that wheel automatically pulls from a cheap **Budget Bin** sub-pool (ratings 40–55) so you're never soft-locked
- Budget remaining should be visible on-screen throughout, same as Hoopgoat's "CAP 0/100" bar, so the tension is always visible

Position: Chosen Last

Position is a deliberate choice, not a spin — the payoff for having sat through 7 random results and finally getting to decide something. Two ways to play it:

- **Position Fit** — each position has an ideal Height/Frame range (e.g. Center wants Height 80+, Frame 70+). Pick a position your build actually fits → +3 OVR bonus and a clean, credible headline.

- **Positional Anomaly** — pick a position your build doesn't fit (a 5'9" Slight-frame Center) → bigger WinTotal variance (higher risk/reward) but unlocks unique badges and the best screenshot-worthy headlines ("history's most unlikely 5").

v2 idea: gate All-NBA/All-Star slots by position (limited Center spots, etc.) once award logic needs more realism.

Overall Rating (OVR)

Weighted average of the 5 skill stats after height/frame modifiers are applied:

$$\text{OVR} = (\text{Shooting} \times 0.20) + (\text{Finishing} \times 0.20) + (\text{Playmaking} \times 0.18) + (\text{Defense} \times 0.18) + (\text{Rebounding} \times 0.14) + (\text{HeightRating} \times 0.05) + (\text{FrameRating} \times 0.05)$$

Weights are tunable, but skill stats should dominate (86% of OVR) with Height/Frame as a smaller direct contribution (10%) on top of their indirect effect via the modifier above.

Team Wheel & Win Total

30 teams, each with a hidden Supporting Cast Rating (SCR, 20–90) representing the quality of the roster you're dropped onto. Contenders sit 75–90, rebuilding teams sit 20–35.

$$\text{WinTotal} = \text{round}(41 + (\text{OVR} - 75) \times 0.9 + (\text{SCR} - 60) \times 0.35 + \text{variance}(-4, +4)) \\ \text{clamp}(\text{WinTotal}, 12, 73)$$

41 is the league-average win total baseline. Your OVR and the team's SCR both pull wins up or down from there; the +/-4 variance keeps every run from being perfectly predictable.

Playoff sim

If WinTotal ≥ 42 (play-in territory), simulate a bracket. Each round is a best-of-7 where your win probability per game is:

$$\text{GameWinPct} = 0.5 + ((\text{OVR} + \text{SCR})/2 - \text{OpponentRating}) \times 0.01$$

OpponentRating is randomly generated per round within a realistic band for that playoff seed. Simulate game-by-game with that win% until someone wins 4.

Awards & Thresholds

Award	Requirement
All-Star	OVR ≥ 75
All-NBA 3rd Team	OVR 80–84
All-NBA 2nd Team	OVR 85–89
All-NBA 1st Team	OVR ≥ 90
MVP	OVR ≥ 90 AND team WinTotal ≥ 50 (weighted random roll among qualifiers)
Ring	Win the simulated Finals
Finals MVP	Win the ring AND OVR ≥ 85

GOAT Score & Tier Ladder

Career sim runs for a randomized number of seasons (8–18), re-rolling WinTotal and awards each year with your OVR held constant (career arcs / aging can be a v2 feature). Composite score at the end:

$$\text{GOATScore} = (\text{PeakOVR} \times 4) + (\text{Rings} \times 15) + (\text{MVPs} \times 12) + (\text{FinalsMVPs} \times 10) + (\text{AllNBA} \times 3) + (\text{AllStars} \times 1) + (\text{CareerWins}/10)$$

Tier	GOAT Score range
Draft Bust	< 100
Bench Piece	100 – 149
Starter	150 – 249
All-Star	250 – 349
Superstar	350 – 449
Legend	450 – 549
GOAT	≥ 550

Ladder visual on the verdict screen mirrors Hoopgoat's pathway UI (dots on a line, current tier lit up), just relabeled to match our 7 tiers instead of their 5. Draft Bust is a deliberate floor, not a punishment screen — bad-luck builds (short, light frame, low everything, dropped on a tanking team) are often funnier to share than good ones, so the verdict screen and headline generator should lean into it rather than downplay it.

Percentile ranking

v1 (no backend yet): approximate percentile via a z-score against an assumed score distribution (mean ~230, stdev ~110, tuned by playtesting). v2: once there's a real user base, replace with an actual percentile against stored past runs. Store best GOATScore locally (or per-account later) to power the "New Personal Best" badge.

The Verdict Screen

- **Player name** front and center in the headline and card, not just a stat block
- **Tier ladder** — Draft Bust → Bench Piece → Starter → All-Star → Superstar → Legend → GOAT, current tier highlighted
- **Percentile badge** — "Top X%" pulled from the z-score calc above
- **New Personal Best** banner if GOATScore beats the stored local best
- **Career totals row** — rings, MVPs, Finals MVPs, All-NBA nods, All-Star nods, peak OVR
- **Team result line** woven into the headline — e.g. "Dragged the Wizards to 45 wins" instead of a bare number
- **Your 7 Legends recap** — every wheel result (Height, Frame, 5 skills) with the player it came from, the budget cost, and which one "carried" the build (highest single contribution to GOATScore)
- **Position + Fit/Anomaly badge** — shows whether the build fit its chosen position or pulled off an anomaly run
- **Final budget spent + rerolls used** — e.g. "97/100, 2/3 rerolls used"

- **Recap headline generator** — fake ESPN chyron built from a template, e.g. "{PLAYER_NAME} STUNS THE LEAGUE: {TEAM} RIDE {TOP_ATTRIBUTE} TO A RING"
- **Play again / share CTA** — re-spin, or export the verdict card as an image for socials

Making It the Best Ever

Roughly cheapest-to-add first — hold off on anything requiring accounts/backend until the core loop is proven fun in solo play:

- **Achievement badges** — "Unicorn Build" (elite height + elite shooting), "Small Ball Terror" (short + elite rebounding), "Two-Way Monster" (elite offense + defense), "Full Send" (spent every last budget point)
- **Shareable verdict card** — export the verdict screen as an image; this is what actually gets posted, not just played
- **Recap article blurb** — a few generated sentences of season narrative, not just a headline, same template-fill approach
- **Historical benchmark comparison** — run real legends (peak Jordan, peak Wilt) through the same formula so "Top 2.1%" has real anchor points instead of an abstract z-score
- **Alt draft mode** — a manual, no-wheel point-cap draft (closer to Hoopgoat's pure strategy mode) as a second mode alongside spins
- **Daily theme** — Hoopgoat's strongest retention mechanic; a rotating constraint (e.g. "Retro Week: only pre-2000 players in the pool") once the core loop is proven

Cost & Scope

Still a weekend-to-a-week build, not a money pit. v1 runs entirely client-side (wheel logic, budget math, sim, GOAT Score) with personal-best stored in local storage — effectively free to build and host (Vercel/Netlify free tier). A domain is the only real optional cost (~\$12/yr). Accounts, leaderboards, and a real percentile backend are the first things that would cost anything, and should wait until the core loop is validated as fun.

Open Questions / Next Decisions

- Is 0.15 the right cost multiplier / is 100 the right cap — needs playtesting once the sim is running to see if budget runs out too fast or too slow
- Should Budget Bin fallback results still show the "nicer" player name at a lower rating, or a genuinely different (lesser-known) player pool for flavor?
- How many real players per wheel pool at launch — 10 per wheel (70 total) is a reasonable v1 scope
- Local storage only for personal best at launch, or worth standing up a lightweight backend from day one?
- Position Fit bonus values (+3 OVR) and Anomaly variance boost need tuning once win totals are visibly testable

Brainstorm doc — formulas are a v1 starting point, meant to be tuned once the sim is actually running and results can be sanity-checked against real feel.